

ChatGPT in University Learning

An Ethical Explorer review of misinformation, data control, and equitable learning support.

SYSTEM

ChatGPT

Conversational AI assistant used for writing, studying, coding, search, and file analysis.

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Course: SWE 263P

June 7, 2026

What is being reviewed

ChatGPT is an AI assistant that responds through conversation. In a university setting, students may use it to brainstorm, explain concepts, draft text, debug code, search the web, or analyze uploaded files and images.

PRIMARY USERS

Students

Also instructors, TAs, advisors, and support staff.

CORE INTERACTION

Prompt -> response

Natural language hides system uncertainty and can feel authoritative.

SENSITIVE INPUTS

Chats + files

Coursework, grades, identity details, accommodations, and personal context.

- Review boundary: everyday university use, not a workplace deployment of ChatGPT Enterprise.
- Ethical concern: how the product behaves when students rely on it for learning decisions.

From risk zones to specific concerns

The Ethical Explorer cards are broad lenses. This review translates the most relevant zones into three concrete concerns for ChatGPT use in coursework.

TOP CONCERN 1

Misinformation

Confident but wrong explanations can distort learning and assessment.

TOP CONCERN 2

Data control

Students may enter sensitive details, including information about classmates.

TOP CONCERN 3

Equity

Uneven access, language quality, and accessibility can widen learning gaps.

Risk zones used

Disinformation / Algorithmic Bias / Data Control / Surveillance / Exclusion / Outsized Power

Prioritization: high relevance to students, plausible harm, and actionable university or product responses.

Confident misinformation in learning

Disinformation + Algorithmic Bias

ChatGPT can produce fluent explanations, citations, or code that sound credible even when they are wrong.

Stakeholders

Students using answers to study or submit work; instructors grading AI-assisted work; classmates affected by shared false notes.

Impact, likelihood, and technology link

Impact: Incorrect understanding, fabricated sources, unsafe academic advice, or misleading code can affect grades and learning confidence.

Likelihood / scale: Medium to high. Example: a student asks for sources for a policy paper and receives plausible article titles, fake DOIs, or non-existent citations that are copied into a bibliography.

Linked design choice: The conversational interface and polished tone can make uncertainty hard to notice; citations are easy to trust unless the workflow pushes source verification.

Reduce harm from confident misinformation

The goal is calibrated trust: ChatGPT can be a tutor or draft partner, but final academic claims need verification by the student and course policy.

ACT

Require verification

For factual assignments, require students to open each cited source, verify DOI/URL existence, and mark AI-generated citations as unverified until checked.

Owner: Instructors and students

INFLUENCE

Teach AI citation hygiene

Add a short syllabus note or class demo showing hallucinated references, stale facts, and when Search/deep research still needs source inspection.

Owner: Instructors and TAs

MONITOR

Track repeated failures

Collect examples of fake citations, wrong code, or bad domain advice and use them to update assignment instructions and student guidance.

Owner: Teaching team

Rationale: The highest-risk failure is not a wrong first draft; it is a confident answer entering submitted work as if it were verified evidence.

Student privacy and data control

Data Control + Surveillance

Students may share more than they realize: drafts, grades, accommodations, health stress, immigration context, or personal information about classmates.

Stakeholders

Students whose data is entered; classmates named in prompts; instructors requiring AI use; university IT and privacy officers.

Specific third-party risk: the person exposed may not be the user. A classmate can be named in a prompt without consent or any chance to correct the record.

Impact, likelihood, and technology link

Impact: Loss of privacy, chilled help-seeking, inappropriate disclosure, or accidental inclusion of protected educational records.

Likelihood / scale: Medium. Example: a student asks ChatGPT to rewrite a peer evaluation or conflict email and includes a classmate name, disability accommodation, grade, or mental-health detail.

Linked design choice: Chat history, Memory, file upload, search query rewriting, and model-improvement data controls all affect how student-provided context can persist or be processed.

Reduce student privacy and data-control risk

Privacy responses should be concrete enough for students to follow during coursework, not just a generic warning to be careful.

ACT

Use privacy defaults

Tell students not to enter names, grades, accommodations, health details, or peer conflicts. For sensitive work, use Temporary Chat, turn off Memory, and disable model training where available.

Owner: Students, instructors, OpenAI UX

INFLUENCE

Set course data rules

Syllabi should separate allowed low-risk use from prohibited use with identifiable student records or third-party personal data.

Owner: Instructors and departments

MONITOR

Escalate protected data

For FERPA-like educational records or required AI use, route through university-approved tools/accounts and privacy review rather than personal accounts.

Owner: University IT/privacy office

Rationale: The risk is avoidable when students know which inputs should never be pasted and which ChatGPT settings reduce persistence or training use.

Bias and unequal learning support

Exclusion + Algorithmic Bias + Outsized Power

ChatGPT can help students learn, but unequal access, uneven language support, and accessibility gaps can distribute benefits unfairly.

Stakeholders

Non-native English speakers, disabled students, first-generation students, low-income students, instructors, and peers in collaborative courses.

Impact, likelihood, and technology link

Impact: Some students receive better tutoring, editing, and coding support while others face weaker outputs, paywalls, suspicion, or inaccessible workflows.

Likelihood / scale: Medium to high. Example: a free user hits limits before a deadline and is moved to weaker support, while another student with paid access gets stronger tutoring and file tools.

Linked design choice: Specific mechanisms include plan-based model/tool limits, uneven speech-to-text quality for accents, weaker multilingual support in some tasks, and accessibility gaps in voice or file workflows.

Reduce inequity in ChatGPT-supported learning

Equity responses should make AI help optional, accessible, and comparable across students rather than an unstated advantage for students with better access.

ACT

Do not assume paid access

Design assignments so students can complete them without paid ChatGPT features. Provide non-AI alternatives or institutionally supported access when AI use is expected.

Owner: Instructors and departments

INFLUENCE

Review accessibility

Check voice, captions, file workflows, and mobile access for students with disabilities, accents, low bandwidth, or limited devices.

Owner: University IT/accessibility office

MONITOR

Monitor uneven outcomes

Ask students where ChatGPT failed by language, accent, disability, plan tier, or device, and adjust course policy or support resources.

Owner: Teaching team

Rationale: If AI support becomes an invisible prerequisite, subscription limits and tool availability turn into an academic advantage.

A practical response portfolio

The practical path is not a blanket ban. It is clear rules, privacy-aware defaults, and equitable access decisions that keep students responsible for final work.

1

Verify academic claims

Require source checks for citations, facts, and code before submission.

2

Protect sensitive data

Avoid personal, classmate, or protected educational details in prompts.

3

Design for equitable use

Do not make paid access or uneven tool quality an unstated course requirement.

Sources used

- OpenAI Help: What is ChatGPT: FAQ: <https://help.openai.com/en/articles/12677804>
- OpenAI Help: Data Controls FAQ: <https://help.openai.com/en/articles/7730893>
- OpenAI Help: ChatGPT Search: <https://help.openai.com/en/articles/9237897>
- OpenAI Help: Does ChatGPT tell the truth?: <https://help.openai.com/en/articles/8313428>
- OpenAI Usage Policies: <https://openai.com/policies/usage-policies/>